PRESS RELEASE PRESS RELEASE

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE: Feb. 11, 2026
Contact: Craig Bryson, Public Information Officer, (248) 645-2000, ext. 2202 (e-mail: cbryson@rcoc.org)
Visit RCOC online at *www.rcocweb.org*

DATA CONFIRMS THAT 2025-26 WINTER HAS BEEN HARDER THAN RECENT PAST YEARS

Beverly Hills, Mich. — While there have not been many large snowstorms so far this winter, the frequent smaller snowfalls combined with the arctic temperatures have resulted in a winter that has challenged road maintenance crews far more than any recent past years – and is costing road agencies significantly more.

"For some people, the fact that we haven't had storms that drop a foot of snow in one day, suggests that we have not had a hard winter," noted Road Commission for Oakland County (RCOC) Managing Director Dennis Kolar. "However, the numbers, and the experiences of our plow drivers, mechanics and other employees tell a far different story."

Data collected by RCOC documents far more salt and brine use this year, far more worker overtime and far more hours devoted to salting and plowing in general than in recent past years. As of Feb. 9 this year, RCOC had used 67,211 tons of salt, which is above the average for the last five full winters of 63,000 tons. For the same time period in previous years (through Feb. 9), the numbers were:

- 2025: 52,200 tons
- 2024: 39,962 tons
- 2023: 31,996 tons

The same is true for liquid brine, the naturally occurring salt water that RCOC sprays on all salt as it is spread by the salt trucks and also uses on some occasions to pre-treat roads and bridges before snow falls and to break up hard pack on the roads. As of Feb. 9, RCOC had used 744,887 gallons of brine. For the same time period in previous years (through Feb. 9), the numbers were:

- 2025: 370,748 gallons
- 2024: 262,983 gallons
- 2023: 222,423 gallons

-- MORE –

WINTER STATS / 2 OF 2

Overtime hours for winter operations staff tell the same story. As of Jan. 31 this year, RCOC had recorded 22,545 hours of overtime for its snowplow/salt truck drivers and supporting staff. At the same point in previous years, the numbers were:

- 2025: 15,573 hours
- 2024: 14,211 hours
- 2023: 12,244 hours

Looking at total hours of winter operations staff devoted to salting and plowing confirms this trend. By the end of January this year, RCOC drivers had recorded 46,612 total hours (regular and overtime) devoted to salting and plowing. For the same time period in previous years, the numbers were:

- 2025: 37,421 hours
- 2024: 28,532 hours
- 2023: 19,589 hours

All those additional hours and extra salt and brine come with a cost.

"Not only has this winter been challenging for motorists and for our drivers," Managing Director Kolar noted, "it will also end up costing us significantly more than recent past winters. And those are dollars spent with no road improvements to show for them."

He added, though, with potentially another month or two of winter, it is too early to say what the total additional cost of winter operations this year will be compared to past years. However, Kolar estimated if the remainder of the winter is just average, the additional cost is likely to exceed $2 million.

Kolar also praised the drivers, mechanics, garage supervisors and others support staff who have worked many long days and nights to keep the roads safe. "Many of our drivers, mechanics and others did not have a single weekend off during January and worked countless extended shifts – some up to 16 hours straight, battling the weather. Not only is that physically grueling, is also time that they are not at home with their families. I cannot thank them enough for their commitment to keeping our roads safe."

-- # # # --